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Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, Founder and Executive Chairperson of Biocon, is one of India's most well-known entrepreneurs. She has managed to do things with a lot of common sense, a lot of determination, and a lot of 'foolish courage'. Mazumdar-Shaw sat down for an exclusive chat as part of the Business Today PODS with Sanjeev Krishan, Chairperson of PwC in India, and Siddharth Zarabi, Editor, Business Today. Edited excerpts:

SIDDHARTH ZARABI: What was that instance of foolish courage that you deployed to get where you are today?

KIRAN MAZUMDAR-SHAW: I started Biocon on a rebound. Why do I say a rebound? Because I came back to India thinking I'm going to pursue a brewing career. And when none of the breweries would offer me a job, I decided to create my own job. And the job I chose was quite daunting in the 1970s, to try and be a pioneer in biotech, which is very capital intensive, and which at that time was a huge risk because nobody understood biotech. I started Biocon in defiance to prove people wrong.

SANJEEV KRISHAN: You're going to be completing 50 years as an organisation soon. How have you managed to take the team together?

KMS: Quite a large number of people, especially in R&D and manufacturing, have been with the organisation for over 25 years. That culture is very important because we have a can-do culture. Remember, a biotech company from India trying to compete globally was a big challenge.

What we've also done over the years is to get a lot of good talent joining our company from outside. Especially during this global transition we've had a large number of very good people join us from different parts of the world.

SZ: Your company employs a lot of young talent. How do you inculcate some good practices in the younger generation?

KMS: I think there is a big difference between the youth of yesteryear and the youth of today. In many ways, people's aspirations are very different today than it was 40-45 years ago. I also believe that people are not ready to stay in a job for too long. I think they all want to basically drop out, which wasn't the case when I started Biocon because jobs were not that easy to find. People would join Biocon with the belief that they would retire here.

SZ: But as an employer, are you okay with people wanting womb-to-tomb jobs?

KMS: You need to strike a balance because you really need to have people with fresh ideas, you don't want

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“For anybody in India, or anywhere in the world, to enter the global biosimilars space, your starting cheque size is a billion dollars. How many people are willing to do that...?”

people who have been doing things in a set way. What succeeded in the past may not succeed in the future.

Today's business environment is totally different. You need to be agile, responsive, and you don't have the luxury of time. There's so much technology hitting you every day, what part of that technology should you adopt, how fast should you adopt new technologies, and how do you become more efficient?

SZ: What qualities would you look for in a youngster applying to join your company?